

Session 11: Humans Formed From Dust

Key Takeaways

- Humans are formed from dust and this signifies that they are from the realm of frail mortality.
- The Genesis 1 waters and the Genesis 2 waters create a combined statement of Yahweh as the master of the chaos waters—the one who can turn them into a source of life.

Genesis 2:7: Humanity Formed From Clay

There are two biblical motifs about human nature whose beginnings are rooted in the language and imagery of Genesis 2:7: “And Yahweh formed (וַיַּצַּר) the human of dust (עָפָר) from the ground.”

Is this line describing a literal creation of the first human by focusing on the material substance from which he was made? Or is this an archetypal description that focuses on the nature and mortality of the human species as a whole?

To answer these interpretive questions, let's focus on the key words “formed” (*yatsar*) and “dust” (*aphar*) and ask two questions.

1. Does the verb form commonly focus on material substance?
2. Is “formed of dust” used to describe only the human of Genesis 2, or does it include other humans as well?

Word Study: Formed — *Yatsar*

Does the verb *yatsar* focus exclusively on the material substance of what is created? The verb appears 45 times in biblical Hebrew. And it takes a variety of direct objects, not all of which are material.

2 Kings 19:25 ESV*

Have you not heard that I made it long ago? I **formed it** from days of old what now I bring to pass, that you should turn fortified cities into heaps of ruins ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here, the word refers to a series of events providentially arranged by God ([Isa. 22:11](#); [46:11](#)).

Isaiah 27:11 NIV*

For this is a people without understanding; so their maker has no compassion on them, and **the one who formed them** shows them no favor.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 43:1 NIV

But now, this is what the LORD says—
he who created you, Jacob,

he who formed you Israel:

“Do not fear, for I have redeemed you; I have summoned you by name; you are mine.”

The entire nation of Israel was formed and made by Yahweh ([Isa. 29:16](#); [43:7](#), [10](#), [21](#); [44:21](#), [24](#); [Ps. 95:5](#)).

Isaiah 45:6-7 NIV*

I am Yahweh, and there is no other.

I form the light and create darkness,

I bring good and create bad;

I, the LORD, do all these things.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here, the word is used for metaphorical descriptions of historical events of abundance and peace or war and defeat ([Jer. 18:1-10](#)).

Isaiah 45:18 NIV*

For this is what the LORD says—he who created the heavens, he is God; **he who formed the land**, and made it; he founded it; he did not create it to be empty, but formed it to be inhabited—he says: “I am the LORD, and there is no other.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The entire cosmos is formed by Yahweh ([Jer. 18:1-10](#); [33:2](#)).

Amos 4:13 NIV

He who **forms the mountains**, who creates the wind, and who reveals his thoughts to mankind, who turns dawn to darkness, and treads on the heights of the earth—the LORD God Almighty is his name.

The mountains and the wind are elements within the cosmos.

Amos 7:1 NIV*

This is what the Sovereign LORD showed me: **He was forming swarms of locusts** after the king's share had been harvested and just as the late crops were coming up.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Here, the word is used to describe Yahweh's actions on swarms of locusts.

Zechariah 12:1 NASB*

Thus declares the Lord who stretches out the heavens, lays the foundation of the earth, and **forms the breath of a human within him ...**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The breath of life that animates humans was also formed by Yahweh.

Psalm 74:16-17 NIV*

The day is yours, and yours also the night; you established the sun and moon. It was you who set all the boundaries of the earth; **you formed both summer and winter.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Summer, winter, and seasonal orders of time are formed by Yahweh.

Psalm 139:16 NIV*

Your eyes saw my unformed body; all **the days you formed for me** were written in your book before one of them came to be.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

A person's "days," that is, the course of their lives, are formed by God.

It's not about literal versus non-literal. The Hebrew word for "formed" can refer to the creation of a material object, but it seems to have a broader meaning of God ordering the cosmos and providentially bringing things to be at the right place and the right time for his purposes. That's the pattern.

Word Study: Dust and Clay

Does dust describe the unique material substance of the first human, or is this an archetypal description of the nature and mortality of the human creature? The words "dust" and "clay" are regularly used to describe humanity as a whole and every human, not just the human in Genesis 2.

Genesis 3:19 NASB

By the sweat of your face you will eat bread, till you return to the ground, because from it you were taken; **for you are dust, and to dust you shall return.**

Psalm 103:14 NASB

For he himself knows our form;
he is mindful that **we are but dust.**

Job 33:4-6 NASB*

The **Spirit/Breath** (רוח) of God has made me, and the **breath** (נשמה) of the Almighty gives me life. Refute me if you can; array yourselves before me, take your stand. Behold, I belong to God like you; **I too have been pinched out of the clay.**

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Psalm 119:73 NASB*

Your hands made me and fashioned me;
give me understanding, that I may learn your commandments.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Job 4:19 NASB

How much more those who dwell in **houses of clay** (חמר), whose **foundation is in the dust** (עפר), who are crushed before the moth!

Job 10:8-9 NASB*

Your hands fashioned and made me altogether, and would you destroy me? Remember now, that **you have made me as clay**; and would you **turn me into dust** again?

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 64:8 NASB*

Yet you, LORD, are our Father. We are **the clay, you are the former/potter**; we are all the work of your hand.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Notice that in all these texts, the language of the Eden narrative is used to describe the nature of all humanity.

Adam, Archetype, and Being Formed From Dust

“Being formed from dust is a statement about [human] essence and identity, not our substance. In this, Adam is an archetype ... If we are all formed from dust, yet at the same time we are born of a mother through a normal birth process, we can see that being formed from dust, while true of each of us, is not a statement about each of our material origins. One can be born of a woman yet still be formed from dust; all of us are. ... “Formed from dust” is not a statement of material origins for any of us, and there is no reason to think that it is a statement of Adam’s material origins. For Adam, as for all of us, that we are formed from dust makes a statement about our identity as mortals. Since it pertains to all of us, it is archetypal.”

Walton, John H. (2015). [*The Lost World of Adam and Eve: Genesis 2-3 and the Human Origins Debate*](#). IVP Academic: An Imprint of InterVarsity Press.

Defining “Archetype”

“Archetype” is a compound word from two Greek words.

1. *Arche*: first, beginning
2. *Tupos*: pattern

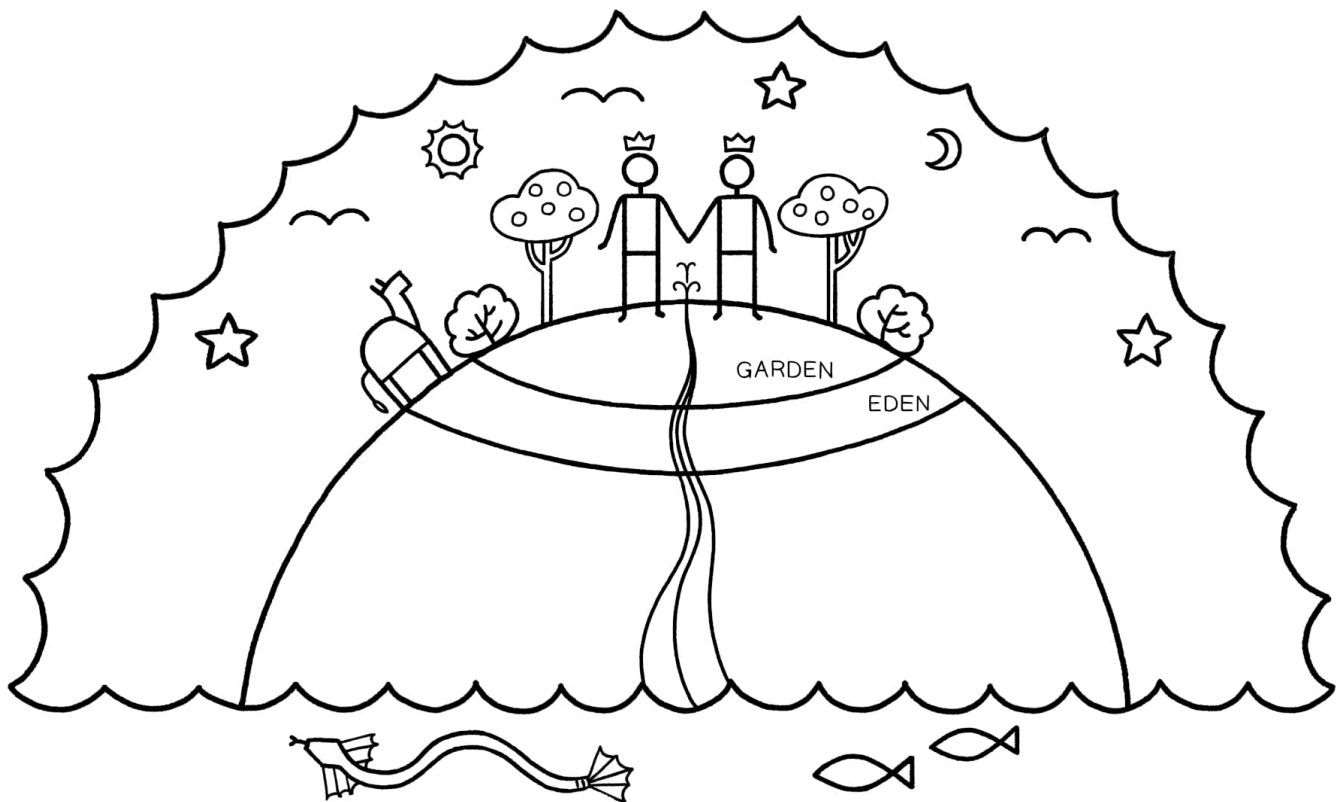
An archetype is an event, person, place, or thing that will begin a series of patterns. The function of the archetype is that what happens in the initial instance will be in common with all later iterations of the pattern.

The literal meaning of the statement that humans are formed of the dust is that humans are from the realm of death and mortality—of non-eternal life. To have eternal life, something else needs to happen.

The Waters of Potential

Both land and water could be seen as chaotic and disorganized mortality or sources of death, but they can also be seen as sources of life and enablers of prosperity. In this passage, we see Yahweh as the agent through which disorganized chaos becomes organized goodness.

The Genesis 1 waters and the Genesis 2 waters form a combined statement of Yahweh as the master of the chaos waters who can turn them into a source of life. When any story happens at a well or a spring, it's an Eden picture that all starts with that stream in Genesis 2.

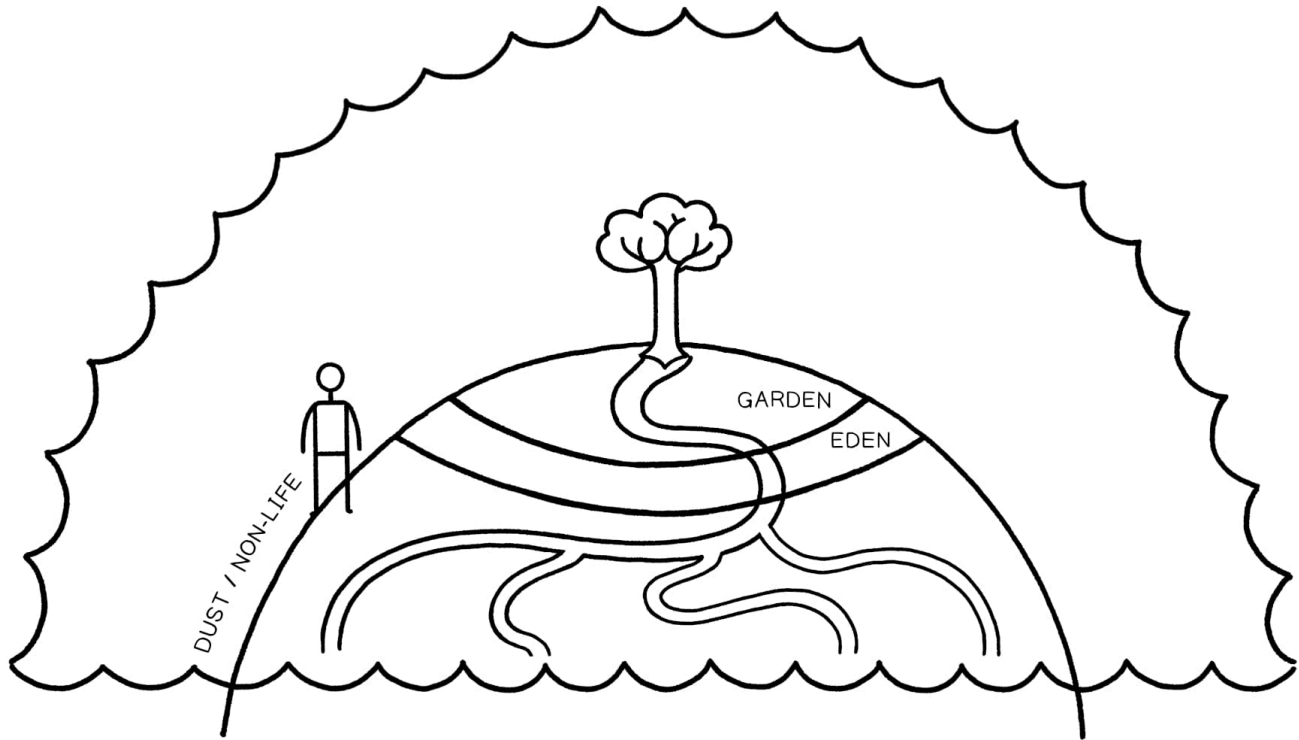


Waters of Potential in Genesis. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Eden and the Three-Part Geography of the Land in Genesis 2:4-17

We've already established the existence of the waters above and below and the dry land in Genesis 1. Now we see a more detailed geography unfold in [Genesis 2:8-9](#).

1. Region of Eden
2. Garden in the region of Eden
3. Trees in the middle of the garden



Three-Part Geography of Eden. Illustration created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Although the humans were formed in the realm of dust/non-life, they were placed in the garden with access to the tree of life. The humans are given the chance to have eternal life, but they forfeit it. The garden of Eden story is about an ideal never realized, not perfection lost.

The biblical story is not: The universe used to be perfect, but then two humans did something wrong that introduced death and everything unpleasant.

The biblical story is: God created a space for his humans to partner with the divine project to spread life and order out of the realm of chaos and non-order.

The Rivers of Genesis 2:10-14

The description of the primordial river in [Genesis 2:10-14](#) has an intentional literary design. Each river is described with decreasing length, imitating a spring running out over the land. Each of the names is associated with various regions of the ancient biblical map.

River	Region	People Groups and Empires
Pishon	Havilah = South and East of Canaan, the NW edge of the Arabian desert	Cainites, Ishmaelites, Edomites, Arabs
Gihon	Cush = Southern Egypt, the upper Nile, Ethiopia	Egyptians and Ethiopians
Hiddeqel	Assyria = The Tigris River	Assyria
Euphrates	Babylonian flood plains	Babylon
<i>Rivers Associated with Ancient Regions. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).</i>		

This Eden-sourced river prepares the reader to view each of these regions (Egypt, Jerusalem and surroundings, and Mesopotamia) as extensions of Eden’s life-giving waters and places that are graced with the life of Eden. This makes perfect sense of the Eden analogies applied to Canaan (Gen. 13:10), Mesopotamia (Gen. 11:1-4), and Egypt (Gen. 13:10; 45:18, 20).

River 1: The Pishon (2:11-12)

The Pishon is given the longest description, which prepares the reader for understanding the significance of future stories.

- “Goes around the land of Havilah”: This is where Ishmael’s descendants will settle (Gen. 25:18) and where Hagar will wander in her flight from Sarah (Gen. 16:7).
- “Good gold” + “aromatic resin” + “onyx stone”: These are all associated with the symbolic Eden gifts given to Israel in their wilderness wanderings. Gold is provided for the tabernacle. Aromatic resin (בדלח) is mentioned in the appearance of the manna (Exod. 16:33; Num. 11:7). Onyx stones (אבן שהם) are in the high priest’s ephod (Exod. 25:7; 28:9).

Treasure Outside the Garden?

Is there significance in the fact that these treasures are not located in the garden, but just outside it? Does this communicate that the garden creates value in the world but is not to be mistaken with those actual treasures? Are we to view these treasures as signals that one is near to the garden, but that these should not be identified with the real treasure of the garden, namely that one can be with God there? [suggestion from Jacob Stromberg]

River 2: The Gihon (2:13)

The Gihon is associated with the land of Cush, which has multiple referents in the Hebrew Bible.

- Southern Egypt (modern Ethiopia): 2 Kgs. 19:9; Esther 1:1; 8:9; Ps. 68:31; Isa. 18:1; 20:3-5; 45:14; Ezek. 29:10; 30:4-5, 9; Nah. 3:9.

- The son of Ham, whose descendants are people of southern Egypt (Gen. 10:6-7). But this very Cush is the father of Nimrod, who goes east to Mesopotamia to build the empires of Assyria and Babylon.
- The name of Gihon spring/river is only elsewhere associated with the spring that supplies water to Jerusalem and the temple (1 Chron. 32:30; 33:14), which is where Solomon was crowned king of Israel (1 Kgs. 1:33, 38, 45).

Rivers 3 and 4: The Hideqel and Euphrates (2:14)

The Hideqel and Euphrates are associated with two Mesopotamian empires. The Tigris flows “to the east of Assyria.” And the Euphrates is left to the reader’s imagination, which is of course supposed to bring Babylon to mind.

“The description of the rivers has been outlined in ‘decrecendo’ form, as each successive description becomes shorter and shorter ... The same pattern is evident in Hebrew word counts, as the four river descriptions are given in 20, 10, 8, and 4, Hebrew words successively. The second river’s description (10 words) is exactly half the length of the first (20 words), and the fourth (4 words) is half the length of the third (8 words). The impression of this most striking feature of Gen. 2:10-14 is precisely that of a spring welling up and dissipating as it flows out all over the land—that is, verses 11-14 demonstrate literarily what is stated explicitly in verse 10.”

Morales, L.M. (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers.

Eden as a Cosmic Mountain

The depiction of Eden as a high place, from which flows a river of divine life that provides life for all of the nations, is foundational for the biblical storyline. Eden is “Heaven on Earth” in the form of a cosmic high place, where the life of Heaven is one with Earth.

Genesis 2:10 Instructor’s Translation

Now, **a river went out** from Eden **to water** the garden; and from there it separated and became four heads ...

Eden is a high enough place for a river to flow out to water various distant regions of the land.

Ezekiel 28:13-14 NASB

You were in **Eden**, the **garden of God** ... you were on the **holy mountain of God**.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Eden is referred to by later biblical authors as a mountain.

Exodus 24:16-18 NASB

¹⁶ The glory of the LORD rested on Mount Sinai, and the cloud covered it for six days; and on the seventh day he called to Moses from the midst of the cloud. ¹⁷ And to the eyes of the sons of Israel the appearance

of the glory of the LORD was like a consuming fire on the mountain top.¹⁸ Moses entered the midst of the cloud as **he went up to the mountain**; and Moses was on the mountain forty days and forty nights.

Exodus 25:8-9 NASB

Let them construct a sanctuary for me, that I may dwell among them. **According to all that I am going to show you, as the pattern of the tabernacle and the pattern of all its furniture**, just so you shall construct it.

The plans for the tabernacle, which was designed as a micro-Eden, were revealed to Moses on top of Mount Sinai, where he encountered Yahweh in the burning tree.

Joel 2:1-3 NIV*

Blow the trumpet in **Zion**, sound the alarm on **my holy mountain** ... before them [the army] the land is like the **garden of Eden**; behind them, a desert wasteland.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Isaiah 51:3 NIV

The LORD will surely comfort **Zion** and will look with compassion on all her ruins; he will make her deserts **like Eden**, her wastelands **like the garden of the LORD**. Joy and gladness will be found in her, thanksgiving and the sound of singing.

Ezekiel 36:34-35 NASB

The desolate land will be cultivated instead of being a desolation in the sight of everyone who passes by. They will say, "This desolate land has become **like the garden of Eden**; and the waste, desolate and ruined cities are fortified and inhabited."

The Jerusalem temple, which was designed to be Heaven/Eden on earth, was built on Mount Zion, a high hill which is constantly likened to Eden.

Psalms 46:4 NIV

There is **a river** whose streams make glad **the city of God**,
the holy place where the Most High dwells.

Psalms 48:1-2 NIV

Great is the LORD, and most worthy of praise, in **the city of our God, his holy mountain**. Beautiful in its loftiness, the joy of the whole earth, like **the heights of Zaphon is Mount Zion, the city of the great king**.

Ezekiel 47:1-12 NIV

¹ The man brought me back to the entrance to the temple, and I saw **water coming out from under the threshold of the temple** toward the east (for the temple faced east). The water was coming down from under the south side of the temple, south of the altar ... ⁵ He measured off another thousand, but **now it was a river that I could not cross**, because the water had risen and was deep enough to swim in—a river that no one could cross. ⁶ He asked me, "Son of man, do you see this?"

Then he led me back to the bank of the river. ⁷ When I arrived there, I saw a great number of trees on each side of the river. ⁸ He said to me, "This water flows toward the eastern region and goes down into the Arabah, where it enters the Dead Sea. When it empties into the sea, the salty water there becomes fresh. ⁹ **Swarms of living creatures will live wherever the river flows ...** ¹² Fruit trees of all kinds will grow on both banks of the river. Their leaves will not wither, nor will their fruit fail. Every month they will bear fruit, because the water from the sanctuary flows to them. Their fruit will serve for food and their leaves for healing."

Joel 3:18 NASB

And in that day, the **mountains will drip with sweet wine**,
and the hills will flow with milk,
and all the brooks of Judah will flow with water;
and **a spring will go out from the house of the LORD**
to water the valley of Shittim.

Revelation 21:10 NASB

And he carried me away in the Spirit to **a mountain great and high**, and he showed me **the holy city**, Jerusalem coming down **out of heaven from God**.

Revelation 22:1 NASB

Then he showed me **a river of the water of life**, clear as crystal **coming from the throne of God and of the Lamb**.

The heavenly Jerusalem, that is, renewed Eden on Earth, is described as a high mountain garden-city that flows with the river of life.

"In Genesis 2-3, Eden is not explicitly described as a mountain, but this can be best understood by a careful reading of many biblical texts that symbolically identify Eden with Zion. Through the temple ritual on Mount Zion, the cosmic images of Eden became an earthly reality. Genesis 2:10-14 mentions the four great rivers that proceed from Eden and water all the earth. One of these cosmic streams is the Gihon, which appears only elsewhere in the Hebrew Bible in reference to the main source of Jerusalem's water ... This connection between the Gihon of Eden and of Jerusalem is not the result of fuzzy or illogical mode of thought on the part of the biblical authors. This symbolic matching reflects Zion's cosmic and spiritual importance ... The image of Jerusalem's cosmic stream is no more inappropriate than similar imagery applied to Jerusalem in Psalm 48:1-3 ("Beautiful in elevation, the joy of the entire earth, Mount Zion in the far north") or Isaiah 2:1-4 ("Mount Zion will be raised up as the highest of all mountains on earth"). In the symbolic world of Israel's temple liturgies, ordinary space became sacred space, the meager water spring of the city became a cosmic river, and the little knoll of Jerusalem became Mount Zion, the highest mountain on the earth, and Jerusalem a peripheral city in the ancient world, became the center of the earth (Ezek. 38:12)."

Anderson, Gary (1988). "The Cosmic Mountain: Eden and Its Early Interpreters in Syriac Christianity," *Genesis 1-3 in the History of Exegesis: Intrigue in the Garden*. 192-93.

The Cosmic Mountain and the Primeval River in the Ancient Near East

"In the ancient Near East, the union of heaven and earth was conceived as a mountain whose base was the bottom of the earth and whose peak was the top of heaven, making it the axis mundi ... the center of the world ... The cosmic mountain was the meeting place of the gods, the source of water and fertility ... the meeting place of heaven and earth. The cosmic mountain motif appears in the literature and religious rituals of Mesopotamia, Egypt, the Hittites, Canaan, and ancient Israel."

Morales, L.M. (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers.

"[Ancient Near Eastern temples] were the architectural embodiment of the cosmic mountain ... [The] pyramids and ziggurats were architectonic representations of the archetype of the cosmic mountain, often decorated with portrayals of the cosmic waters and fertile trees. The connection between temples and cosmic mountains is related to their function as links between heaven and earth, as attested by the names of the Babylonian sanctuaries ("Mountain of the house," "House of the Mountain of all Lands"), so that the ziggurat was literally and symbolically a cosmic mountain."

Morales, L.M. (2012). [*The Tabernacle Pre-Figured: Cosmic Mountain Ideology in Genesis and Exodus*](#). Peeters Publishers.



Keel, Othmar; Hallett, Timothy J. (translator) (1997). *The Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

This image is from a carving on a fountain from an Assyrian temple (8th-7th cent. B.C.). It depicts a deity whose body is a tall forest mountain, and four primal rivers go out into the world as a gift of his own divine life.



Keel, Othmar; Hallett, Timothy J. (translator) (1997). *The Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

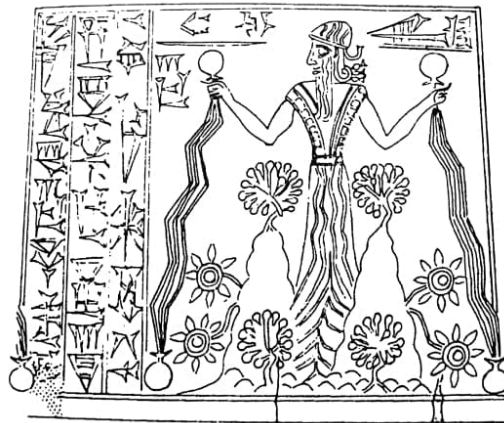
“A highly interesting wall painting from Mari (191) shows a rectangular space surrounded by a wall ... flanked by date palms and trees ... four cherubim, and two bulls. One foot of each bull is planted on a mountaintop. The two mountains probably indicate that the center of the court is located on a mountain. The two fountain deities in the lower of the two smaller rectangles correspond to the two mountains. A stream with four branches (as in Gen. 2:10) rises from the vessels held by the deities. A stylized plant grows out of the stream. This is the place from which all life issues. In the center of this region, in the upper rectangle, stands Ishtar, the goddess of fertility, love, and war ... Her right foot is set on a lion. The king stands in greeting before her. She appears to be presenting him with ring and staff. In any case, the picture depicts all parts of an entire temple complex. The temple building is a broad room with a wide antechamber (cf. 172-73, 207). The anteroom and the forecourt incorporate all those features which characterize the temple as a sphere of life. We find these features repeated—almost without exception—in the Solomonic temple and in the description of paradise: the mountain (Ezek 28:13-16), the rivers, the trees, the cherubim. Even the bulls are present. In the Jerusalem temple they carried the bronze sea (1 Kgs 7:25). Belief in the presence of the living God supplied the temple forecourts with all the symbols which had already played a role in the Ishtar temple of Mari.”

Keel, Othmar; Hallett, Timothy J. (translator) (1997). [*The Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*](#). Eisenbrauns.



Keel, Othmar; Hallett, Timothy J. (translator) (1997). *The Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

Image of Assyrian relief found in a fountain in the Temple of Asshur (patron god of Assyria, 1800-1500 B.C.). A combination of two river deities (four streams total), who issue from the mountain god and supply all plant life (notice the tree of life goat motif). This image depicts Asshur as the chief of the cosmic mountain, supplying vegetation and water to the cosmos.



Keel, Othmar; Hallett, Timothy J. (translator) (1997). *The Symbolism of the Biblical World: Ancient Near Eastern Iconography and the Book of Psalms*. Eisenbrauns.

Kassite cylinder seal (14th cent. B.C.). Between forested mountain tops, the mountain god rises and provides rivers of life and vegetation for his realm. The rain waters come from his hands, and the primeval river flows from his skirt.

The Design Pattern of the Primeval River

Because the garden of Eden represents the union of Heaven and Earth, its river is portrayed as the source of all the world's fertility and abundance. When later biblical authors portray the arrival of God's deliverance and restoration of Jerusalem and all creation, it is no surprise that they draw upon this river imagery.

And in that day the mountains will drip with sweet wine,
and the hills will flow with milk,
and all the brooks of Judah will flow with water;
and **a spring will go out from the house of the LORD** to water the valley of Shittim.

Isaiah 30:23-26 NIV

²³ **He will also send you rain** for the seed you sow in the ground, and the food that comes from the land will be rich and plentiful. In that day your cattle will graze in broad meadows ... when the towers fall, **streams of water will flow on every high mountain and every lofty hill.** ²⁶ The moon will shine like the sun, and the sunlight will be seven times brighter, like the light of seven full days, when the LORD binds up the bruises of his people and heals the wounds he inflicted.

Zechariah 14:6-9 NIV

⁶ On that day there will be neither sunlight nor cold, frosty darkness. ⁷ It will be a unique day—a day known only to the Lord—with no distinction between day and night. When evening comes, there will be light. ⁸ On that day **living water will flow out from Jerusalem**, half of it east to the Dead Sea and half of it west to the Mediterranean Sea, in summer and in winter. ⁹ The LORD will be king over the whole earth. On that day there will be one LORD, and his name the only name.

Psalms 36:7-9 NIV

⁷ How priceless is your unfailing love, O God!
People take refuge in the shadow of your wings.
⁸ They feast on the abundance of your house;
you give them drink from your river of delights.
⁹ For **with you is the fountain of life;**
in your light we see light.

Ezekiel 47:1-12 NIV

¹ The man brought me back to the entrance to the temple, and I saw **water coming out from under the threshold of the temple** toward the east (for the temple faced east). The water was coming down from under the south side of the temple, south of the altar ... ⁵ He measured off another thousand, but **now it was a river that I could not cross**, because the water had risen and was deep enough to swim in—a river that no one could cross. ⁶ He asked me, “Son of Man, do you see this?”

Then he led me back to the bank of the river. ⁷ When I arrived there, I saw a great number of trees on each side of the river. ⁸ He said to me, “This water flows toward the eastern region and goes down into the Arabah, where it enters the Dead Sea. When it empties into the sea, the salty water there becomes fresh. ⁹ **Swarms of living creatures will live wherever the river flows ...** ¹² Fruit trees of all kinds will grow on both banks of the river. Their leaves will not wither, nor will their fruit fail. Every month they will bear fruit, because the water from the sanctuary flows to them. Their fruit will serve for food and their leaves for healing.”

Reflection Question

What idea is being emphasized in Genesis 2 when God forms the human from the dust?